

Mt Ritter via Lake Ediza SE Glacier Route, Clyde Variation
2010-07-24 to 2010-07-26
Sierra Club M-Snow Provisional



After a weekend unexpectedly opened up a few months back I was able to attend one of the two Sierra Club snow check offs held each year in the Sierra. After a rather entertaining day spent flinging myself down steep slopes to demonstrate self arrest, building snow anchors out of various sundry pieces of gear, and generally being grilled about how not to get people killed in technical snow terrain they passed me.



That wasn't completely unexpected but certainly made things interesting. I requested provisional status based on the private snow climbs I'd been leading lately and sure enough I was given the thumbs up.

Logically I could wait until the next snow season or find something with snow to climb in the middle of the summer. Never one to wait patiently I settled on the highest peak in the Mammoth area and the star of the annual WTC popsicle lecture. Basically in the 1970s 5 people set off to climb this peak and after a very bad storm rolled in and a series of bad decisions were made only one made it out alive. That would be Mount Ritter. (Middle peak in the picture below)



So cut to a month or so and much paperwork later and I was picking up Ron Campbell, fellow leader who had agreed to evaluate me on this trip. For Ron Ritter was a grudge peak as he'd had to turn around the previous year due to time after losing two teeth to rock fall. I was determined to get him to the top this year.

We left Orange County around 2:45 pm and due to traffic, fires, and a Palmdale DUI checkpoint we set my personal record for longest drive to Mammoth. We were actually beat to the campground by Joe and Joel who left Sylmar at 6:45 pm.

Everyone eventually arrived and we took a spot at the Agnew Meadows campground. The mosquitoes, always an issue in the Sierra this time of year, were eating me alive so despite the warm weather I climbed inside my bivy to get some relief. As a result I was only moderately chewed up and managed a fitful sleep to the sound of mosquitoes bussing around outside the face mesh.

Day 1: Get Me The Hell Away From Civilization



The next morning at 7 am we were at the nearby trailhead parking lot waiting on our 6th and final member. Unfortunately he was nowhere to be seen and so after running through the usual Sierra Club paperwork rituals we were off.

Other than my evaluator Ron we had Joe, Joel, and Jack along for the adventure.



The area was scenic to say the least. We were constantly running into lakes and hiking along high running streams.



The area is extremely high use and we ran into a number of others on the trail.



We also fought a constant battle with the mosquitoes that swarmed us whenever we stopped even momentarily.



After 4 or 5 miles we took a break at Shadow Lake where the mosquitoes were lighter due to wind and Jack used the opportunity to drop a line into the water.



Unfortunately due to the massive amount of mosquitoes around the fish weren't interested.



We continued on and came to our goal, Lake Ediza.



Ron claimed it was one of the most scenic areas in the Sierra and I find myself having to agree with him.



Unfortunately it was also a bit of a mosquito pit. I had informed Ron I intended to climb the slope behind the lake until we escaped the mosquitoes but unfortunately that proved impossible.

It started to rain on us sporadically as I found a site several hundred feet above the lake and in the perfect position below a snow chute we'd be climbing the following day.



We set up camp below the Clyde variation chute leading to Ritter via the SE glacier route.

We scouted another route I'd been interested in climbing but it quickly became apparent conditions were not ideal. Clyde variation it would be.



When we returned back to camp everyone else took a nap until dinner. I went and made friends with a marmot.



We ate dinner and watched the sun go down eyeing the peaks we'd be climbing the next day.

Day 2: Summit Day

I had told everyone to be ready to go at 4:45 am but I think every last one of us actually woke up early. The weather was surprisingly warm which made it easy to climb out of the warm cocoons of our sleeping bags.



4:45 am found a surprisingly awake and cheerful group ready to follow me up the summit.



First we had several stream crossings to accomplish which were rather exciting by headlamp.



Still pre dawn and amid a light drizzle we strapped on our crampons and prepared to start up the steep snow slope above.

Was we worked our way up the slope and the sky lit up behind us giving us an awesome view of Lake Ediza.





Once to the top of the chute the climb turned into a traverse across snow with the occasional patch of rock.



Ritter was looming above us by now. While it appeared temptingly close we still had two thousand feet to climb.



First we had to get to the SE glacier and cross it.



As expected the weather was starting to look less promising. As time passed it was looking less and less likely we'd be able to summit.

We pressed on.



The scale of the SE glacier unfortunately didn't come through in the pictures. Each little mark on the snow was a 6+ inch snow cup and the total effect was quite awesome.



After crossing the glacier we climbed up something known as the Owen's Chute. Crampons now came off and the biggest challenge was arranging the group so that any rocks knocked loose didn't result in any lost teeth such as had happened on a trip here last year.



The top of the chute let out on to the upper snow bowl.



I led the way up the surprisingly steep far end of the upper snow bowl to the summit ridge. The weather looked threatening in the distance but was holding. We were going to make the summit.



Peeking over the edge of the summit ridge there was quite a drop.

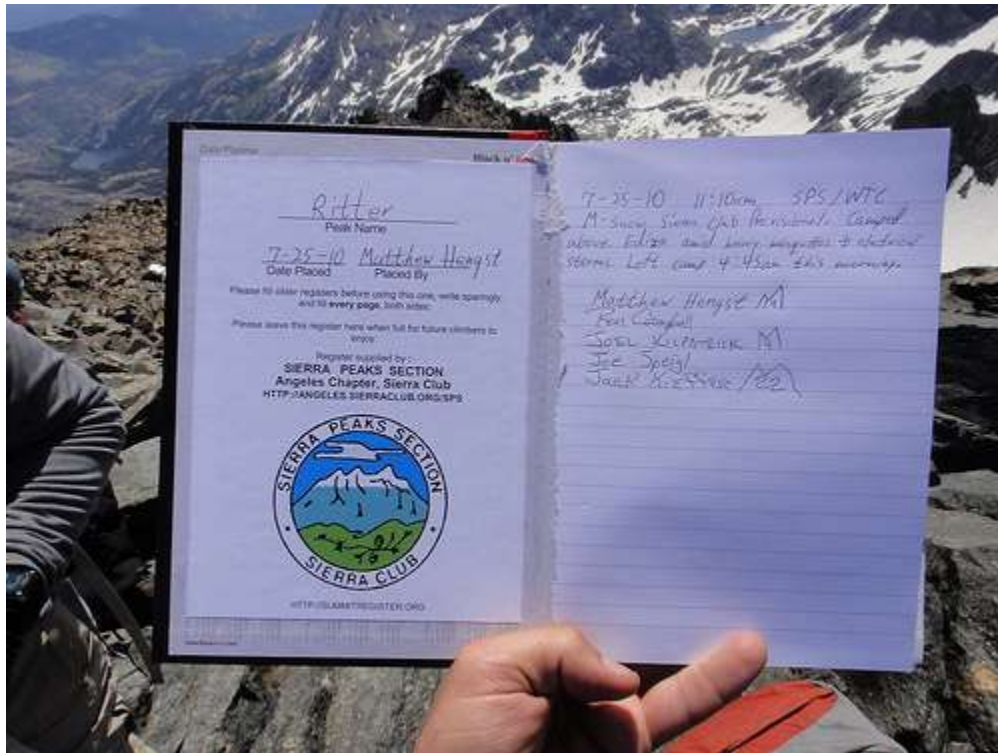


At long last, success.





The previous register was damaged by water and I was carrying the replacement. Hence we became the first group to sign in to the new book.



My original plan involved descending the far side of Ritter to the saddle between it and Banner. Due to the storms in the distance and the rather firm forecast of lighting in the afternoon I was worried we'd end up partway down the chute dealing with wet rock amid a lightning storm. As a result I took us back down the way we came.

Now we just had to get down to a safe altitude before the weather reached us.





Clouds rolled in over the ridge and conditions looked more and more threatening.



As we crossed the glacier we were hit with a light rain. Fortunately we were past the rock section at this point.



We could see down strikes in the distance and hear the rumble of thunder for most of the descent. They were a safe distance away but I pushed the group to continue down without any long breaks.



Eventually we made it back to our camp area.



We started to cook dinner when the hardest rain of the day hit. It only lasted a few minutes then the mosquitoes swarmed back.

I had been carrying my usual pack along with extra clothes, water, a half length rope, and several pieces of webbing in case we hit impassible terrain and I needed to make an anchor and lower anyone down. I was quite tired by the time I made it back to camp and was quite happy to crawl into my tent at 8 pm and escape the mosquitoes.

Day 3: Damnit, But I Don't Want To Leave

The following morning I let everyone awaken with the sun and pack up leisurely as we had a relatively easy walk out.



Around 8 am we were all packed, fed, coffee'd to the gills, and ready to go.



Surprise surprise we were chased by clouds of mosquitoes all the way down. Still the scenery was beautiful.



We bid adieu to Lake Ediza.

We stopped again at Shadow Lake and Jack again made a futile attempt to catch a fish. Meanwhile further down the short Joel and I stripped down and went for a swim. After three days of sweating and smearing ourselves with DEET and sunscreen the water was refreshing. And freezing cold. Did I mention Shadow is glacier fed?



Jack soon came over and joined us while Ron took pictures and shook his head at us like we were crazy folk.

We went in multiple times feeling quite clean and refreshed afterwards once feeling returned to our extremities.



The rest of the hike out was pretty but uneventful.



That's Mammoth Mountain in the background.



Proof I brought everyone out without major maiming. Smiles! Teeth! All limbs intact!

We reached the cars around noon.



Before heading for town we went by a local overlook that gave a view back towards the peak we'd climbed. Ritter is second from the right and actually taller than the rest you can see.

After that it was all over except for the celebration. We drove in to town and had lunch at a local restaurant called Base Camp.



(The guy in the background is a boy scout hitchhiker we ran into on the trail and gave a ride in to town.)

This trip was done despite of a broken tailbone that caused me quite a bit of discomfort but was manageable. It was a good proof of concept that I was healed enough to get back up the mountains after three weeks of being basically bedridden.

Next weekend, Center Basin.